

Nominalism



For Duns Scotus, the universals were simply adjectives used to describe the properties of real-world objects.

Because Plato's philosophy had been firmly assimilated into Christian doctrine from the time of Augustine, the introduction of Aristotle's contrasting ideas met with some resistance. Scholastic philosophers adopted a rigorous Aristotelian methodology, but his views on the problem of Universals (see [Abelard and Universals](#)) were seen as contradicting Church teachings. Peter Abelard was among the first to challenge the idea of

realism (that the Universals have a real, independent existence) with his idea of conceptualism (that they exist only in our minds). Thirteenth-century philosophers such as John Duns Scotus and William of Ockham went further, arguing that the Universals did not exist *at all*, except as names referring to properties of things in the real world. Unlike Aquinas's synthesis (see [Thomas Aquinas](#)), this 'nominalist' idea directly contradicted realism. Christian philosophy split into opposing schools of thought on the issue – a division echoing differences between Plato and Aristotle, which persisted well beyond the Renaissance between continental rationalists and British empiricists.